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*“A soul in tension that’s learning to fly
Condition grounded but determined to try...”
Learning to Fly, Pink Floyd (1987)*

These lines from the iconic British rock band Pink Floyd’s 1987 hit are emblematic of aviation. For, it’s trying and trying again that has enabled humankind to fulfil its dream to fly. And amid warnings of a changing climate, there is a growing aspiration to make flying sustainable. But since caring for the environment demands a massive overhaul of existing technologies as well as copious expenditure, it’s not going to be easy. So, when Air India’s low-cost subsidiary AirAsia India successfully operated the country’s first commercial flight on the Pune-Mumbai sectors using an indigenously produced sustainable aviation fuel (SAF) blend on the morning of May 19, the world’s fastest-growing aviation market achieved yet another milestone on its flight towards sustainability.

“SAF’s efficacy as an aviation fuel has already been proven across the world. Within the country, we have put in place some thoughts in terms of what that mix should be and we’re looking at blending 1 per cent of SAF by 2025, 2 per cent by 2028, and 5 per cent by 2030 in regular aviation turbine fuel (ATF),” Jyotiraditya Scindia, Minister of Civil Aviation, tells *Business Today*.

For the past several months, Scindia’s ministry has been coordinating with the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas on guidelines for promoting SAF by getting Indian carriers to use it with ATF. “By 2025, if we target blending 1 per cent SAF in jet fuel, India would require around 140 million litres of SAF per annum. More ambitiously, if we target for 5 per cent SAF blend, India requires around 700 million litres of SAF per annum,” says Hardeep Singh Puri, Minister of Petroleum and Natural Gas.

Globally, aviation accounts for over 2 per cent of man-made carbon emissions, according to the International Air Transport Association (IATA). In 2021, IATA’s members committed to achieving net-zero carbon emissions by 2050 on projections of the sector generating 1.8 billion tonnes of emissions if fuelled by ATF. To achieve this, 65



THE FLIGHT TO SUSTAINABILITY

1

Although aviation currently accounts for just over 2 per cent of global CO₂ emissions, the industry is expanding faster than road, rail or shipping

2

Global aviation body IATA’s members have committed to achieving net zero by 2050

3

The number of airlines operating flights using jet fuel blended with sustainable aviation fuel (SAF) is increasing annually

4

Other green initiatives include highly fuel-efficient engines, taxibots to tow aircraft to takeoff point, minimising use of single-use plastics, reducing food waste and carbon-mapping airports



GREEN FUEL CHALLENGE

1

Emissions in 2021 reached around 720 million tonnes, regaining nearly one-third of the drop from 2019 levels seen in 2020

2

Over the next 27 years, 65 per cent of total emission reductions are projected to be achieved using SAF

3

To date, globally more than 450,000 flights have operated using SAF globally

4

Growth in airline traffic by 2050 likely to generate 1.8 billion tonnes of carbon emissions if fuelled by traditional kerosene-based ATF

5

But it’s important to bring down per litre cost of SAF as it is up to five times more expensive than traditional jet fuel